

had to change their living patterns—and their living places—to keep up with the weather.

In cold climates, you need to stock food, clothing . . . and prepare shelter . . . in anticipation of bad weather. In some places, growing seasons are only a few months long. People had to work night and day in order to put aside enough for the long, cold season ahead. Whether this brought about a change in the habits of mind that cause a person to think about the future—or whether the harsh climate merely eliminated people who could not prepare for it—we don't know. But somehow the idea took . . . and became more than an idea; it became a cultural rule.

No doubt, the notion that thinking ahead pays off was reinforced by the introduction of agriculture. It was one thing to gather wild grains. It was quite another to plant them. Planting required prepared land, seed and, in the warm, dry climates of Mesopotamia and Egypt, irrigation. All of these things forced people to think ahead. And they required sacrifice in the present for the sake of the future.

How many families went to bed hungry rather than “eat their seed corn”? They had to sacrifice . . . to forbear . . . to discipline themselves to not eat the kernels of corn they had spared for planting, or they would not have any corn to harvest the next year. People must have also learned to save not only *some* corn, but the best corn, for those were the best seeds. So a family had to deprive itself of its best food . . . in order to have more later on.

A quick look at a map will also reveal another curiosity. Look at places that are rich. Then look at places where people are poor. Take Haiti, for example. It is one of the poorest countries on Earth. It is also one of the easiest places to grow food. Go figure. Want to find other easy places to grow food? Just look at some of the poorest countries in the world: the Democratic Republic of Congo, Burundi, and Liberia.

Now take a look at Switzerland. It is perhaps the richest country on Earth. It is also one of the hardest places to grow food. Go figure again. And look at other relatively rich countries: Sweden, Norway, Denmark, Germany, Britain.

Is it a coincidence that these are difficult places to grow food? Where, for thousands of years, people had to look ahead, plan, and prepare in order to avoid going hungry?